Andreeva Fights Back to Beat Sabalenka

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Mirra Andreeva was losing badly. Then she turned the match around.

The 19-year-old from Russia was 4-1 down in the first set against Aryna Sabalenka, the world number two, at the **WTA Finals**. But Andreeva found her best tennis and never let go. She won 11 games in a row and took the match 6-4, 6-0. The win sent her into the last four.

Andreeva mixed high, **looping** balls with strong shots from the back of the court. She hit 16 **winners** and made only six mistakes. When she served for the first set at 15-30 down, she hit three **aces** in a row.

Sabalenka started well and led by two **breaks**. But after that she won only 10 more points in the whole match, and she finished with 23 mistakes.

Andreeva said afterwards that Sabalenka did not have her best day, and that she was happy. Andreeva now goes through as the winner of her group. Sabalenka can still reach the last four if she beats Elina Svitolina on Friday.

Word Treasure

WTA Finals -- The big end-of-season tennis event where the best women players compete.
winners -- A shot so good that the other player cannot reach it.
aces -- A serve that the other player cannot touch, so it wins the point at once.
breaks -- Winning a game when the other player is serving.
looping -- Curving high through the air in a big arc.

Background you need

In tennis, players hit the ball back and forth over a net, and the first to win enough games takes a set.

The WTA Finals is a big end-of-season event where the best women players face each other in groups, and the top players move on to the last four.

A player who is losing can still fight back by changing how she hits the ball, as Andreeva did with high, looping shots and strong hits from the back of the court.

Break it down

WHO: Mirra Andreeva, a 19-year-old tennis player from Russia, and Aryna Sabalenka, the world number two.

WHAT: Andreeva came back from 4-1 down in the first set to win the match 6-4, 6-0 and reach the last four.

WHERE: At the WTA Finals.

WHY: Andreeva found her best tennis, mixing high, looping balls with strong shots, while Sabalenka made many mistakes.

Why it matters

It shows that a game is never over until the last point, so keeping going when you are losing can turn things around.

Test what you remember

1. What was the score when Andreeva was losing in the first set?

- (A) 15-30 down
- (B) 6-4
- (C) 6-0
- (D) 4-1 down

2. How many games in a row did Andreeva win?

- (A) Eleven
- (B) Sixteen
- (C) Ten
- (D) Six

3. How many winners did Andreeva hit?

- (A) Sixteen
- (B) Six
- (C) Ten
- (D) Twenty-three

4. What did Andreeva do when she served for the first set at 15-30 down?

- (A) She took a break
- (B) She lost the set
- (C) She hit three aces in a row
- (D) She made three mistakes

5. How many points did Sabalenka win after her strong start?

- (A) Ten
- (B) Twenty-three
- (C) Six
- (D) Sixteen

6. What must Sabalenka do to still reach the last four?

- (A) Beat Elina Svitolina on Friday
- (B) Beat Andreeva again
- (C) Win eleven games in a row
- (D) Win her group

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: A 4: C 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Mirra Andreeva: She said Sabalenka did not have her best day, and that she was happy with the win.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):